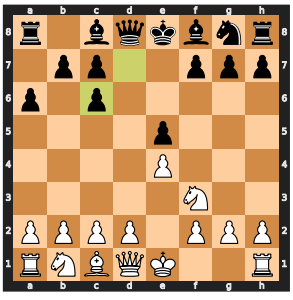


Ruy Lopez



Lasker – Capablanca

St. Petersburg, 1914

White: Dr. E. Lasker Black: J. R. Capablanca

Notes by J. R. Capablanca, from Chess Fundamentals *(1921), which is in the public domain.*
Descriptive notation has been converted to algebraic. Page references are to the book.
Click any move or diagram to open it on Lichess.

1.e4 e5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.♗b5 a6 4.♗xc6

The object of this move is to bring about speedily a middle-game without Queens, in which White has four Pawns to three on the King's side, while Black's superiority of Pawns on the other side is somewhat balanced by the fact that one of Black's Pawns is doubled. On the other hand, Black has the advantage of remaining with two Bishops while White has only one.

4...dxc6 5.d4 exd4 6.♕xd4 ♕xd4 7.♘xd4 ♗d6

Black's idea is to Castle on the King's side. His reason is that the King ought to remain on the weaker side to oppose later the advance of White's Pawns. Theoretically there is very much to be said in favour of this reasoning, but whether in practice that would be the best system would be rather difficult to prove. The student should notice that if now all the pieces were exchanged White would practically be a Pawn ahead, and would therefore have a won ending.

8.♘c3 ♘e7

A perfectly sound form of development. In any other form adopted the Black Knight could not be developed either as quickly or as well. e7 is the natural position for the Black Knight in this variation, in order not to obstruct Black's Pawns, and also, in some eventualities, in order to go to g6. There is also the possibility of its going to d4 via c6 after ...c5.

9.0–0 0–0 10.f4

This move I considered weak at the time, and I do still. It leaves the e-pawn weak, unless it advances to e5, and it also makes it possible for Black to pin the Knight by ♗c5.

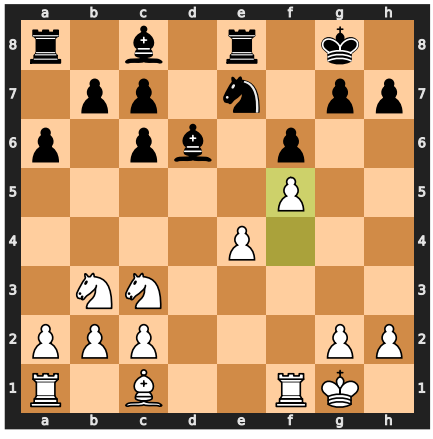
10...♖e8

Best. It threatens ♗c5; ♗e3, ♘d5. It also prevents ♗e3 because of ♘d5 or f5.

11.♘b3 f6

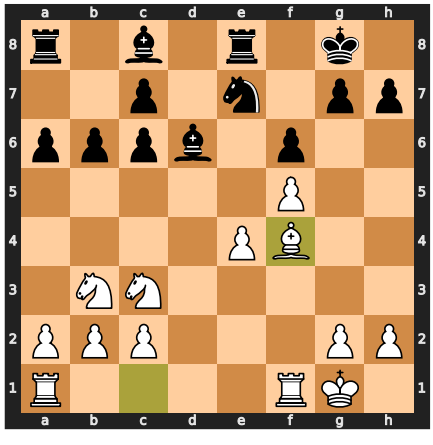
Preparatory to ...b6, followed by ...c5 and ♗b7 in conjunction with ♘g6, which would put White in great difficulties to meet the combined attack against the two centre Pawns.

12.f5



It has been wrongly claimed that this wins the game, but I would like nothing better than to have such a position again. It required several mistakes on my part finally to obtain a lost position.

12...b6 13.♗f4



13...♗b7

Played against my better judgment. The right move of course was 13...♗xf4. Dr. Lasker gives the following variation: 13...♗xf4 14.♖xf4 c5 15.♖d1 ♗b7 16.♖f2 ♖ad8 17.♖xd8 ♖xd8 18.♖d2 ♖xd2 19.♘xd2, and he claims that White has the best of it. But, as Niemzovitch pointed out immediately after the game, 16...♖ad8 given in Dr. Lasker's variation, is not the best. If 16...♖ac8! then White will have great difficulty in drawing the game, since there is no good way to stop Black from playing ♘c6, followed by ♘e5, threatening ♘c4. And should White attempt to meet this manoeuvre by withdrawing the Knight at b3; then the Black Knight can go to d4, and the White Pawn at e4 will be the object of the attack. Taking Dr. Lasker's variation, however, whatever advantage there might be disappears at once if Black plays 19...♘c6, threatening ♘b4 and also ♘d4, neither of which can be stopped. If White answers 20.♘d5 ♘d4 for Black will at least draw. In fact, after 19...♘c6 Black threatens so many things that it is difficult to see how White can prevent the loss of one or more Pawns.

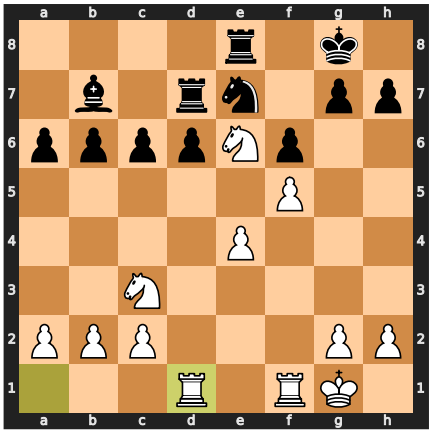
14.♗xd6 cxd6 15.♘d4

It is a curious but true fact that I did not see this move when I played 13...♗b7, otherwise I would have played the right move 13...♗xf4.

15...♖ad8

The game is yet far from lost, as against the entry of the Knight, Black can later on play ...c5, followed by ...d5.

16.♘e6 ♖d7 17.♖ad1



I now was on the point of playing ...c5, to be followed by ...d5, which I thought would give me a draw, but suddenly I became ambitious and thought that I could play the text move, 17...♘c8, and later on sacrifice the exchange for the Knight at e6, winning a Pawn for it, and leaving White's

e-pawn still weaker. I intended to carry this plan either before or after playing ...g5 as the circumstances demanded. Now let us analyse: 17...c5. If 18.♘d5 ♗xd5 19.exd5 b5; and a careful analysis will show that Black has nothing to fear. Black's plan in this case would be to work his Knight around to e5, via c8, b6, and c4 or d7. Again, 17...c5 18. ♖f2 d5 19.exd5 ♗xd5; 20.♘xd5 (best, since if 20. ♖fd2 ♗xe6 give Black the advantage), 20... ♖xd5 21. ♖xd5 ♘xd5; and there is no good reason why Black should lose.

17...♘c8 18.♖f2 b5 19.♖fd2 ♖de7 20.b4 ♔f7 21.a3 ♗a8

Once more changing my plan and this time without any good reason. Had I now played 21... ♖xe6 22.fxe6+ ♖xe6; as I intended to do when I went back with the Knight to c8, I doubt very much if White would have been able to win the game. At least it would have been extremely difficult.

22.♔f2 ♖a7 23.g4 h6 24.♖d3 a5 25.h4 axb4 26.axb4 ♖ae7

This, of course, has no object now. Black, with a bad game, flounders around for a move. It would have been better to play 26... ♖a3 to keep the open file, and at the same time to threaten to come out with the Knight at b6 and c4.

27.♔f3 ♖g8 28.♔f4 g6

Again bad. White's last two moves were weak, since the White King does nothing here. He should have played his Rook to g3 on the 27th move. Black now should have played 28...g5+. After missing this chance White has it all his own way, and finishes the game most accurately, and Black becomes more helpless with each move. The game needs no further comment, excepting that my play throughout was of an altogether irresolute character. When a plan is made, it must be carried out if at all possible. Regarding the play of White, I consider his 10th and 12th moves were very weak; he played well after that up to the 27th move, which was bad, as well as his 28th move. The rest of his play was good, probably perfect.

29.♖g3 g5+ 30.♔f3 ♘b6 31.hxg5 hxg5 32.♖h3 ♖d7 33.♔g3! ♔e8 34.♖dh1 ♗b7 35.e5 dxe5 36.♘e4 ♘d5 37.♘6c5 ♗c8 38.♘xd7 ♗xd7 39.♖h7 ♖f8 40.♖a1 ♔d8 41.♖a8+ ♗c8 42.♘c5

Resigns.